Northstar Systems Pvt. Ltd.

Comprehensive Employee Handbook

Handbook Version:	4.5
Effective Date:	September 1, 2026
Owner:	People Operations & Legal Compliance
Applicability:	All Full-Time Employees, Part-Time Staff, Trainees, and Interns globally

1. Handbook Purpose, Scope, and Legal Precedence

1.1 Purpose and Intent

This Employee Handbook outlines the core workplace practices, professional expectations, benefit structures, conduct standards, information security responsibilities, and operational procedures for Northstar Systems Pvt. Ltd. ("the Company"). It is designed to foster a transparent, high-performing, and secure working environment.

1.2 Scope and Hierarchy

- **Personnel Coverage:** This handbook applies universally to regular full-time employees, part-time personnel, interns, and trainees. Independent contractors and external consultants are governed primarily by their commercial service agreements.
- **Legal Precedence:** This handbook serves as a general operational guide and does not supersede individual employment contracts, binding offer letters, collective bargaining agreements, or mandatory local statutory labor laws. Where local statutory regulations establish a higher standard or conflicting requirement, the applicable local law takes precedence.

2. Employment Categories and Records

2.1 Full-Time Employees

Personnel scheduled for the standard full-time work pattern (typically 40 hours per week) who qualify for comprehensive company benefits based on role classification, geographical location, and applicable plan documents.

2.2 Part-Time Employees

Personnel working a reduced weekly schedule. Benefit eligibility, accrual rates, and leave entitlements are calculated on a prorated basis in accordance with local labor rules and plan terms.

2.3 Interns and Trainees

Individuals engaged for structured learning, professional apprenticeships, or short-term project assignments. Stipends, working hours, mentorship supervision, and completion criteria are governed by dedicated internship agreements.

2.4 Contractors and Third-Party Consultants

Independent workers engaged under commercial business-to-business agreements. They are not eligible for employee-only benefit plans, internal leave accruals, or corporate equity programs.

3. Working Hours, Attendance, and Time Tracking

3.1 Standard Working Hours

The standard corporate workday spans **9:30 AM to 6:30 PM local time**, Monday through Friday, including a mandatory one-hour meal break. Individual teams may adopt alternative schedules or shift rotations to satisfy client support and global operational requirements.

3.2 Attendance and Punctuality

Employees are expected to log their attendance accurately using the designated HR portal. Frequent unannounced absences, habitual tardiness, or the falsification of time records constitute severe performance infractions and will result in corrective disciplinary action.

3.3 Cross-TimeZone Collaboration

Employees operating across distributed time zones must maintain reasonable responsiveness during agreed regional overlap hours and keep their calendar status updated in the corporate scheduling system.

4. Remote, Hybrid Work, and Workspace Security

4.1 Hybrid Work Eligibility

Eligible roles may participate in approved hybrid or remote work arrangements, subject to direct managerial authorization, business continuity needs, role suitability, and demonstrated productivity.

4.2 Remote Workspace Obligations

Employees authorized to work remotely must:

- Maintain a secure, high-speed broadband connection and a private, distraction-free workspace.
- Protect all company-issued hardware, security tokens, and physical access badges.
- Prohibit unauthorized household members or visitors from viewing sensitive client data or source code.
- Avoid discussing confidential corporate matters in public venues (e.g., cafes, public transport, shared co-working lounges).

4.3 Revocation of Remote Privileges

Remote work is a flexible operational arrangement rather than an unconditional legal right. The company reserves the right to modify or revoke remote work privileges based on changing business needs, performance deficiencies, or security non-compliance.

5. Leave Framework, Time Off, and Absence Management

5.1 Annual Leave (Vacation)

- Full-time employees accrue annual paid leave according to their employment grade and regional statutory rules.
- All planned time off must be submitted and approved via the HR portal at least two weeks in advance for absences exceeding three consecutive days.

5.2 Sick Leave and Medical Notifications

- Employees unable to attend work due to illness must notify their direct manager via email or Slack before 9:30 AM.
- Official medical certification from a licensed physician is mandatory for continuous sick leave absences exceeding **three (3) consecutive working days**.

5.3 Public Holidays and Statutory Leaves

- Employees observe public holidays corresponding to their official office location or designated regional holiday calendar.
- Parental, bereavement, civic jury duty, and military service leaves are administered in strict compliance with local statutory mandates.

6. Compensation, Payroll, and Performance Incentives

6.1 Payroll Schedule

Employees are compensated on a monthly or bi-weekly basis as specified in their offer letters and payroll calendars. Payslips are accessible securely through the employee self-service portal.

6.2 Payroll Discrepancies

Employees must review their payslips promptly. Suspected calculation errors or missing allowances must be reported to the payroll support channel (payroll@northstarsystems.io) within thirty (30) days of the pay date.

6.3 Performance Incentives and Bonuses

Discretionary performance bonuses, commissions, or equity grants are contingent upon individual KPI achievement, team delivery milestones, and overall company financial health. Written plan documents govern specific eligibility rules.

7. Benefits Administration

7.1 Comprehensive Benefit Offerings

Eligible staff receive health insurance coverage, life insurance, retirement or provident-fund contributions, wellness allowances, and employee assistance program (EAP) access based on their operational region.

7.2 Plan Governance

Benefit coverage limits, deductible structures, dependent enrollment windows, and claim exclusions are governed strictly by master insurance contracts and benefit plan documents. This handbook provides a summary and does not constitute the binding benefit policy.

8. Performance Management and Professional Development

8.1 Performance Review Cycles

Employees establish quarterly OKRs (Objectives and Key Results) with their managers and participate in formal bi-annual performance evaluations. Reviews assess technical execution, code quality, collaboration, communication, and adherence to company core values.

8.2 Corrective Performance Plans

When performance gaps arise, managers will initiate coaching and targeted support. Persistent underperformance may result in a formal Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) spanning 30 to 90 days.

8.3 Learning and Development Support

The company encourages continuous upskilling. Access to company-funded certifications, external workshops, or conference fees requires prior managerial approval and budget allocation.

9. Code of Conduct and Professional Ethics

9.1 Professional Behavior

All personnel must maintain a respectful, honest, and collaborative demeanor in all interactions with colleagues, clients, vendors, and industry partners. Harassment, bullying, or disrespectful conduct is strictly prohibited.

9.2 Conflicts of Interest

Employees must avoid financial, commercial, or personal relationships that conflict with the business interests of Northstar Systems. Any potential conflict (such as secondary employment, familial vendor relationships, or advisory roles) must be formally disclosed to People Operations.

9.3 Anti-Bribery, Gifts, and Hospitality

- Employees must not offer, solicit, or accept extravagant gifts, kickbacks, cash, or hospitality that could influence or appear to influence business decisions.
- Modest corporate promotional items or business lunches of nominal value are acceptable.

10. Workplace Respect, Anti-Harassment, and Whistleblowing

10.1 Zero-Tolerance Policy

Northstar Systems maintains a zero-tolerance policy toward unlawful discrimination, sexual harassment, racial bias, intimidation, and verbal or physical threats.

10.2 Reporting Channels

Concerns or grievances can be reported directly to a manager, People Operations, or anonymously through the dedicated Ethics Hotline. All complaints will be investigated promptly and confidentially.

10.3 Non-Retaliation Protection

The company strictly prohibits retaliation of any kind against an employee who reports a good-faith concern or participates in an internal compliance investigation.

11. Information Security, Data Privacy, and Confidentiality

11.1 Protection of Confidential Information

Proprietary source code, unreleased product roadmaps, customer lists, pricing structures, financial records, and employee PII constitute strict company confidential information and must never be disclosed to unauthorized third parties.

11.2 Digital Security Best Practices

- Enforce Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) across all corporate accounts and password managers.
- Lock workstation screens whenever leaving the device unattended.
- Immediately report phishing emails, malware alerts, or lost hardware devices to the Security Operations Center (secops@northstarsystems.io).

12. Acceptable Use of Technology and Generative AI

12.1 Company Systems Usage

Corporate hardware and software networks are provided primarily for business operations. Incidental personal use is permitted provided it does not violate security rules, consume excessive bandwidth, or interfere with job duties.

12.2 Generative AI and External Tools

- Employees must adhere to strict data-handling guidelines when utilizing generative AI tools.
- **Prohibited:** Submitting unmasked customer PII, internal source code, or proprietary financial projections into unapproved, public external AI platforms.

13. Expense Reimbursement and Business Travel

13.1 Business Expense Policy

All business-related expenses must be pre-approved by a manager, incurred reasonably, and submitted via the expense portal with itemized tax receipts attached within **thirty (30) days** of purchase.

13.2 Non-Reimbursable Expenses

Personal upgrades, alcoholic beverages, traffic fines, family travel expenses, and minibar charges are strictly non-reimbursable.

14. Workplace Health, Safety, and Emergency Protocols

14.1 Safety Obligations

Employees must comply with all posted safety guidelines, maintain uncluttered walkways, and immediately report workplace hazards or near-misses to the facilities team.

14.2 Emergency Evacuation

In the event of a fire or facility emergency, staff must follow floor warden instructions, utilize marked emergency stairwells (never elevators), and assemble at the designated courtyard assembly point.

15. Disciplinary Process and Corrective Action

When policy violations, security breaches, or behavioral infractions occur, the company follows a progressive disciplinary framework:

1. **Verbal / Written Coaching:** Informal discussion for minor infractions.
2. **Formal Written Warning:** Issued for repeated or moderate policy breaches.
3. **Suspension or Final Warning:** For serious infractions, pending investigation.
4. **Employment Termination:** Immediate separation for gross misconduct, data theft, fraud, or harassment.

16. Separation, Offboarding, and Knowledge Transfer

16.1 Resignation and Notice Period

Employees resigning from the company must provide the contractual notice period in writing to their manager and People Operations.

16.2 Offboarding Obligations

Prior to the final working day, departing employees must:

- Complete comprehensive knowledge transfer and handover documentation.
- Return all company-owned hardware, security keys, access badges, and credit cards.

- Securely delete any cached local copies of confidential company data. Post-employment confidentiality obligations remain legally binding indefinitely.